

sometimes conceals real darkness beneath its melodic surface.

Early talent and versatility

Born in Nelahozeves, a village near Prague, Antonín was already a fine musician by the age of 18. His chief instrument was the viola—intriguingly, the instrument of choice for many leading composers, including Mozart and Schubert. But he was also a good violinist, pianist, and organist, indeed someone to whom composition would have seemed natural.

Studying the organ in Prague, he evaded pressure to follow his father into the family business: although a fine folk musician and zither player (bringing his son influence from that musical world), Dvořák senior was a butcher by trade.

For 11 years, Antonín played in the viola section in the orchestra of the Provisional Theater (later the National Theater), Prague, whose conductor was the Czech national composer in chief, Bedřich Smetana. Dvořák is believed to have taken part in a concert conducted by Wagner in 1863. He later remembered “following [Wagner] as he walked along the streets to get a chance now and again of seeing the great little man’s face.” The versatile young Dvořák supplemented his income by giving piano lessons—and fell in love with one of his pupils, Josefina Cermáková. His love was sadly unrequited. This might be the point at which a sense of heartbreak began to loom under the bright surface of his music. Nevertheless, in 1873 he married Josefina’s sister, Anna, and the couple soon started what became a large family.

Dvořák’s financial status, though, was perilous at the time.